

World in Brief: Iran threatens to keep Hormuz shut; a win for moderate Democrats in Wisconsin



Photograph: Getty Images

The new head of **Iran's** Supreme National Security Council said the **Strait of Hormuz** would not reopen until America “changes its behaviour” and accepts Iran’s [conditions](#) for ending the war, according to Iranian state media. Meanwhile attacks on shipping escalated: on Tuesday America said it had struck a cargo ship entering the Gulf of Oman, while Iran-backed Houthis attacked one in the Bab el-Mandeb strait.

Francesca Hong, a progressive, narrowly lost to David Crowley, a moderate, in the **Democratic** primary for governor of Wisconsin, ending the [populist left's winning streak](#). Ms Hong had been ahead in polls. In Minnesota Peggy Flanagan, another progressive, won the Democratic nomination for Senate. In the Republican primary for Minnesota governor, Lisa Demuth defeated Mike Lindell, an election denier and pillow magnate endorsed by Donald Trump.

Natarajan Chandrasekaran, the chairman of **Tata Sons**, said he will step down after his term ends in February. The board of [India's largest conglomerate](#) has been arguing for months over whether to reappoint Mr Chandrasekaran, with one member refusing to approve an extension. It is a bad time for the ship to be rudderless

—Tata Sons was about to expand, including into semiconductor manufacturing.

Chuck Schumer, the leading Democrat in America's Senate, demanded Congress be briefed on a **covert mission** to smuggle Mr Trump out of Turkey last month. The president reportedly used a catering truck to reach a military jet following an Iranian assassination threat. Lawmakers thought he was travelling on Air Force One. "It is unacceptable that Congress...learned about this serious threat through press reports," Mr Schumer said.

Rescue teams continued to dig through the rubble of collapsed buildings in western **Colombia** in a race to find survivors from Monday's 7.4-magnitude earthquake. Reuters reported that the death toll from the quake had risen above 250. Colombia's new president, Abelardo de la Espriella, who had been inaugurated just days before, travelled to the affected regions and promised economic support.

China's central bank granted **Deutsche Bank**, a German lender, permission to clear transactions in **yuan**. It will be the first European bank allowed to do so. China has been challenging the American-led financial system, pushing its currency as an alternative to the dollar, and its cross-border inter-bank messaging and payment system as a substitute for incumbent systems like SWIFT and CHIPS.

Following a conversation with Vladimir Putin, Mr Trump announced that **Russia** had released a former American marine from prison "on a humanitarian basis". Robert Gilman was arrested in 2022 for allegedly attacking a police officer while drunk. His family dispute the charge. Senator Ed Markey of Massachusetts, Mr Gilman's home state, says he was tortured in jail. Mr Trump said no [exchange of prisoners](#) took place.

Figure of the day: 90%, the proportion of American Gen Zs that went to the cinema in 2025, more than any other generation. Read about why they [have rediscovered their love for the movies](#).

US in brief: a split decision in centrist-leftist primaries



Photograph: AP

David Crowley unexpectedly beat **Francesca Hong** in the Democratic primary for governor in **Wisconsin**. According to polls Ms Hong, a Democratic socialist, had seemed likely to continue the left's winning streak. But Mr Crowley picked up late support from other candidates and consolidated the vote against Ms Hong, who had spooked centrists with past comments such as a call to cancel Thanksgiving (which she recanted). Mr Crowley will face Tom Tiffany, the Republican winner, in the much-watched swing state.

In **Minnesota** the progressive Democrats picked up a win as Peggy Flanagan, the lieutenant governor, beat Angie Craig in a Senate primary. Ms Flanagan supports Medicare for all and wants to “rip ICE apart” after the immigration agency’s violent and aggressive enforcement campaigns in her state. In the Republican primary for governor **Mike Lindell**, founder of MyPillow and an indefatigable supporter of Donald Trump’s claims that the 2020 election was stolen, lost to Lisa Demuth, the speaker of the state’s House of Representatives.

The Trump administration rescinded a ban on **TikTok** from government devices, according to a memo signed on Monday and released on Tuesday. The Justice Department recently determined that such restrictions, passed during the Biden administration, no

longer apply to TikTok, because its Beijing-based owner has since created a new [American version of the app](#) and reduced its stake in it to 19.9%. The White House frequently uploads videos to more than 7m followers on the platform.

Russia released a former American marine from prison “on a humanitarian basis”, Mr Trump said. Robert Gilman was arrested in Russia in 2022 for allegedly attacking a police officer while drunk. His family dispute the charge. Ed Markey, senator of Massachusetts, Mr Gilman’s home state, accused Russia of torturing him in jail. Mr Trump said no [exchange of prisoners](#) took place.

America's murky economic indicators



Photograph: Alamy

The Federal Reserve has two mandates: to keep people in employment and to keep prices stable. Are these starting to pull in opposite directions? Inflation is above the 2% target, which suggests that interest rates should rise, while the jobs market is showing signs of cooling, which argues for holding steady. Indeed, last week's announcement of an unexpected fall in non-farm payrolls in July tempered expectations of an interest-rate hike. Markets now see a 50% chance that the Fed will raise rates at its September meeting, down from nearly 60% last week.

Much depends on forthcoming inflation readings, like the consumer-price data for July, released on Wednesday. Economists expect headline inflation of 3.4% year on year and core inflation, which strips out food and energy, of 2.5%. The Fed's preferred inflation gauge, the PCE price index, is running hotter. Fed officials will watch the next two inflation reports closely before their September policy meeting. If price pressures ease and employment continues to weaken, the Fed may be able to avoid raising rates, and provoking Donald Trump.

Europe plunges into darkness

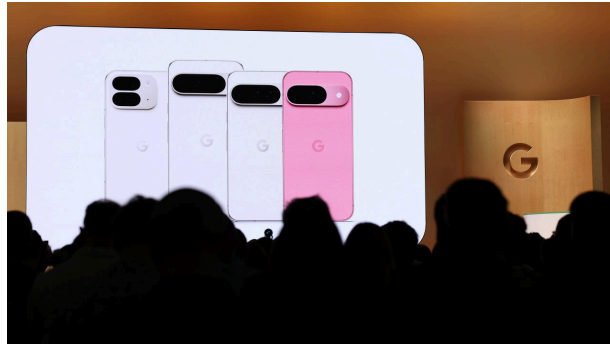


Photograph: Getty Images

Parts of Europe will see their first total eclipse of the sun since 1999 on Wednesday. More than 400,000 visitors are expected to flock to the path of totality, from which the whole star is obscured. Unlike a lunar eclipse, in which Earth's shadow on the Moon can be seen wherever the Moon is visible, a solar eclipse, in which the Moon throws its shadow onto Earth, is visible only briefly from places along this narrow geographical band.

This eclipse begins at the Taymyr peninsula in Siberia, crosses the Arctic Ocean, makes landfall over Greenland, Iceland and Spain, and ends in the Mediterranean. It has a maximum totality of 138 seconds, but only off the coast of Iceland. For viewers in Spain, where the weather forecast is most propitious, totality will happen around 8.30pm, local time, with the eclipsed sun low on the western horizon.

Google hones its phones for AI



Photograph: Getty Images

Google will unveil the latest generation of its Pixel smartphones on Wednesday. Expect the tech giant to boast about their artificial-intelligence capabilities. Google was among the first to run AI models directly on users' devices, answering many queries faster and more securely than if they were processed by data centres. This is an increasingly valuable niche as hardware and small AI models become more powerful. Even Apple, a longtime rival, has signed up to use Google's models in its devices.

But prices are getting steeper as phones get smarter. Google's new Pixels will probably cost about \$100 more than last year's equivalents. (Samsung, another rival, recently increased the price of its Galaxy smartphones by similar amounts.) The cost of the memory chips they use doubled between late 2025 and early 2026, as AI infrastructure gobbled up capacity. Some American tech companies have reportedly lobbied the government to ease restrictions on buying [Chinese chips](#). In the meantime, customers upgrading their smartphones may be dumbfounded by the price.

America's fast-food chains catch an illness



Photograph: Reuters

Ordering a salad in a restaurant is normally the healthy choice. But America is in the middle of a nasty outbreak of cyclosporiasis, a parasitic infection that spreads through food and water, causing nausea and diarrhoea. This particular scourge began in some iceberg lettuce grown in Mexico and sold in America by Taylor Farms, a big food distributor. The Centres for Disease Control and Prevention, America's public-health body, has received more than 10,000 reports of cases since May.

That has been bad news for both salad-sellers and salad-eaters. The first reports of the illness were linked to Taco Bell, a [fast-food chain](#) that sprinkles shredded lettuce on lots of its dishes. Its parent company said same-store sales have dropped by 2% during the quarter to date as a result. Chains not publicly linked to the outbreak have also suffered. Sweetgreen, a salad spot, recently slashed its annual sales projections due to consumer worries about fresh produce, even though it does not serve iceberg lettuce.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Who directed the first two Harry Potter films?

Tuesday: Which London landmark, designed by Sir George Gilbert Scott, features sculptures representing four continents, and four arts and sciences, as well as of the central figure it is named after?

*The true method of knowledge is
experiment.*

William Blake